THE PRESIDENCY



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WELL DESERVED Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets the new president

conscientious and hardworking, and someone who never forgot her roots. It was during this stint that Murmu ensured that the five km stretch from Kadauni on the state highway to her home in Uparbeda became a pucca road.

However, the course of Murmu's life changed when she lost her two sons in quick succession, and then her husband. Having nearly lost her mind, and sunk into deep depression, it was only after she joined a Brahmakumari unit that Murmu managed to regain control over her self and her surroundings. She set up a school in memory of her husband and sons, which she ran as a public service, and also devoted herself to social welfare and the upliftment of tribals. Her work caught the eye of both the RSS and the BJP and Murmu was made governor of Jharkhand in 2015, a post she handled with grace and dignity along with firmness till she demitted office at the end of her term in July 2021.

As President of India, Murmu's powers will be largely ceremonial. She will be bound by the advice and consent of the Union council of ministers headed by the prime minister. Under the Constitution, the President appoints the prime minister and Union ministers, and he or she is also the supreme commander of the armed forces. But while these powers are only notional, officials who have served in the office of the president say that each incumbent leaves his or her stamp on the office. So, if Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam was a 'people's president', Pranab Mukherjee played elder statesman. Ram Nath Kovind continued Kalam's legacy of demystifying the presidency, and Murmu is expected to raise tribal awareness and consciousness, even though presidents resent being identified by caste or community; the office is meant to be representative of all citizens. Kovind, for instance, disliked being called a Dalit president.

PRESIDENT MURMU'S ROLE

Where the presidents do play a crucial role is if a general election returns a hung Parliament. The President then has the discretion to act in a manner he or she thinks appropriate. When the 1989 general election did not throw up any clear winner, the then president R. Venkataraman went by the principle of inviting the leader of the largest party to form the government. The Rajiv Gandhi-led Congress, which had won 197 seats, was given the first choice, but when he declined, Venkataraman called V.P. Singh, the Janata Dal leader, who accepted. He then asked Singh to prove his majority. K.R. Narayanan preferred to look at the strength of pre-poll alliances and wanted letters of support as proof before he invited a claimant to form the government, as Atal Bihari Vajpayee had to do in 1998. The President can also show their displeasure over a bill passed